Silk Road Salts | Loyalty Intelligence

Review-Derived NPS for five specialty-salt competitors · Amazon US star histograms + written reviews · analysis generated 2026-10-11

1. Competitive Loyalty Analysis

Rank	Competitor	Product (Amazon US)	Amazon ratings	5★	4★	1–3★	NPS	Recorded
1	The Spice Lab	The Spice Lab Cyprus White Flake Kosher Salt, 8 oz bag ASIN B0030MZMIK	63	92.0%	4.0%	4.0%	**+88**	2026-10-10
2	Maldon Salt	Maldon Salt, Sea Salt Flakes, 8.5 oz (240 g) ASIN B00017028M	47,071	89.0%	8.0%	3.0%	**+86**	2026-10-10
2	Redmond Real Salt	Redmond Real Salt - Ancient Fine Sea Salt, Unrefined, 16 oz pouch ASIN B071FNYFWW	24,210	90.0%	6.0%	4.0%	**+86**	2026-10-10
4	SaltWorks	SaltWorks Pacific Blue Sea Salt, Kosher Flake, 8 oz pour-spout pouch ASIN B077NRHK1F	973	85.0%	10.0%	5.0%	**+80**	2026-10-10
5	Jacobsen Salt Co.	Jacobsen Salt Co. Pure Flake Sea Salt, 4 oz ASIN B01M32JS5F	1,275	83.0%	8.0%	9.0%	**+74**	2026-10-10

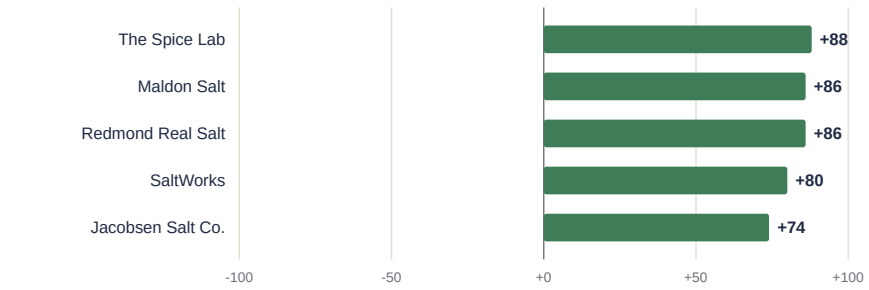
Star shares from each listing's rating histogram, hand-recorded (data/raw/histograms/star_histograms.csv), normalized to their sum. Amazon rounds each share to a whole percent, so each NPS carries up to ±2 points of rounding error. Histograms include star-only ratings and are labeled 'global ratings' by Amazon.

Four products are plain flake finishing salts; Redmond Real Salt sells no flake salt, so its fine-grain everyday salt is used. Its loyalty reflects a different use case (daily cooking salt) and package size, which limits direct comparison. Total analyzed written reviews: 1264. Source: Amazon US written reviews retrieved through Woot's public review endpoint (woot.com/review/Reviews/<ASIN>), using the open-source mrlong0129/amazon-review-scraper. Records are "source-retrieved", not independently matched to amazon.com permalinks.

Bucket boundaries

Promoter = 5★; Passive = 4★; Detractor = 1–3★. NPS = %Promoters − %Detractors, computed at full precision and rounded to a whole number. Five stars is the clearest written expression of enthusiasm; four-star reviews frequently carry reservations, mirroring the survey's 7–8 "passive" band; 1–3 stars signal dissatisfaction or materially qualified experience. These thresholds are judgment calls, so a sensitivity test follows. This is a **Review-Derived NPS**, not an official survey NPS.

Review-Derived NPS (baseline)



2. Methodology, Sensitivity & Evidence

Alternative specification: 4–5★ = Promoter, 1–3★ = Detractor, no Passives

Competitor	Baseline NPS	Alternative NPS	Change (pts, exact)	4★ share	Rank: base → alt
The Spice Lab	+88	+92	+4.0	4.0%	1 → 2
Maldon Salt	+86	+94	+8.0	8.0%	2 → 1
Redmond Real Salt	+86	+92	+6.0	6.0%	2 → 2
SaltWorks	+80	+90	+10.0	10.0%	4 → 4
Jacobsen Salt Co.	+74	+82	+8.0	8.0%	5 → 5

Computed on the Amazon star histograms (headline basis). The exact change always equals the 4★ share; displayed rounded values can differ by ±1 point due to rounding.

Written-review sample (reference only; used for themes and quotes)

Competitor	n	Promoter	Passive	Detractor	Sample NPS	95% CI
The Spice Lab	41	85.4%	12.2%	2.4%	**+83**	+70 to +96
Maldon Salt	511	22.9%	23.3%	53.8%	**-31**	-38 to -24
Redmond Real Salt	497	22.5%	22.5%	54.9%	**-32**	-40 to -25
SaltWorks	40	70.0%	7.5%	22.5%	**+48**	+22 to +73
Jacobsen Salt Co.	175	70.3%	8.6%	21.1%	**+49**	+37 to +61

Retrieval capped each star bucket at ~110–125 reviews, so sample shares reflect the cap for heavily reviewed products.

Three classified excerpts (verbatim, from stored records)

> **5★ Promoter** — Redmond Real Salt, 5★, 2026-10-07, id srs-0b78ec1e3ca4, source: Woot review endpoint (woot.com/review/Reviews/{ASIN}), Amazon US review data (product page)
> *"This is my favorite salt. I have bought it several times and am never disappointed."*

> **4★ Passive** — Redmond Real Salt, 4★, 2026-09-13, id srs-bd75c4a42fa2, source: Woot review endpoint (woot.com/review/Reviews/{ASIN}), Amazon US review data (product page)
> *"THIS SALT HAS A LOT OF MINERALS PLUS NO PLASTIC LIKE SEA SALT"*

> **1–3★ Detractor** — Redmond Real Salt, 3★, 2026-10-03, id srs-74cf58b2c8c4, source: Woot review endpoint (woot.com/review/Reviews/{ASIN}), Amazon US review data (product page)
> *"Came quickly. Smaller than expected and recently learned its been testing for significant levels of heavy metals. Pricier than other options anyway"*

Selection bias

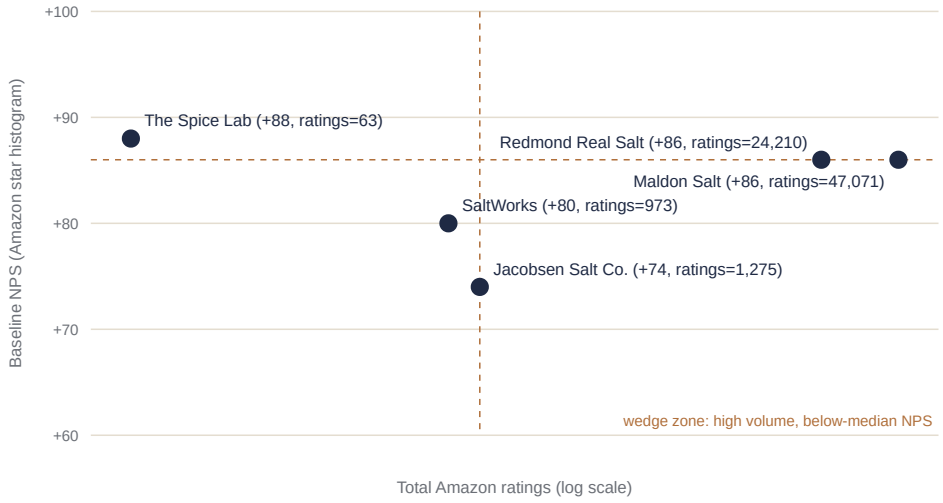
Online reviews overrepresent customers with unusually positive or negative experiences, creating a potentially bimodal distribution that exaggerates apparent customer polarization relative to the broader customer base.

- Headline scores use each listing's Amazon star histogram, hand-recorded from the live page (date and recorder stored). Histograms cover all ratings, including star-only ratings, and Amazon labels them 'global ratings', which may include other Amazon stores.

- Amazon shows whole-number percentages, so each histogram NPS carries up to about +/-2 points of rounding error; differences of a few points are not meaningful.
- Written-review samples (capped at ~110-125 per star by the Woot endpoint) are used only for themes and excerpts; their sample NPS is shown for reference.
- Review-derived NPS is not a survey of all purchasers; reviewers self-select (voluntary response bias).
- Possible fake or incentivized reviews (including Vine) are not removed; they are disclosed where flagged.
- Product-level, not company-wide, loyalty: one SKU per brand.
- Review volume is not sales volume.

3. Where Should Silk Road Salts Compete?

Loyalty vs. review volume



X-axis: Total Amazon ratings shown on each listing (hand-recorded; includes star-only ratings).

1. Competitive overview

5 of 5 competitors have comparable scores from each listing's Amazon star histogram (hand-recorded; ±2 pts rounding). Baseline NPS ranges from +74 (Jacobsen Salt Co., 1,275 ratings) to +88 (The Spice Lab, 63 ratings). The Spice Lab (+88), Maldon Salt (+86), Redmond Real Salt (+86) are within the combined rounding error (±2 pts each) of one another, so their order is not meaningful. Small rating base: The Spice Lab (63 ratings). Written-review samples (used below for themes and quotes) are capped at ~110–125 reviews per star, so their sample NPS is shown for reference only.

2. Entry wedge (measured)

Rule: total Amazon ratings ≥ median (1,275) and baseline NPS below median (+86.0). Qualifying: Jacobsen Salt Co. (1,275 ratings, NPS +74). Jacobsen Salt Co. qualifies on volume only by sitting exactly at the median (3 of 5 by volume, well below Maldon Salt at 47,071). Ratings count is a proxy for sales, not a measure of it, so this is a candidate wedge, not a proven one.

3. Customer dissatisfaction evidence → Silk Road response (hypothesis)

Keyword-rule coding of 595 retrieved detractor (1–3★) reviews. A review can match several themes; capped retrieval over-samples detractors of the most-reviewed products, so counts show what complaints say, not how common they are among buyers; rules are in pipeline/analyze.py and every match stores its review ID.

Theme	Detractor reviews	% of detractors	Competitors	Proposed response (untested)
Sourcing / authenticity / contaminants	144	24.2%	Maldon Salt (6), Redmond Real Salt (138)	Provenance documentation and third-party purity testing per lot.
Flavor / taste quality	104	17.5%	Maldon Salt (34), Jacobsen Salt Co. (4), SaltWorks (3), Redmond Real Salt (63)	Small-batch infusions using whole botanicals; tasting notes on pack.
Shipping damage / delivery	104	17.5%	Maldon Salt (99), Redmond Real Salt (5)	Protective secondary packaging for glass; ship-test before launch.

Representative complaint excerpts

- *“Came quickly. Smaller than expected and recently learned its been testing for significant levels of heavy metals. Pricier than other options anyway”* — 3★, Redmond Real Salt, id srs-74cf58b2c8c4 (Sourcing / authenticity / contaminants)
- *“I found this irritating! The flakes just bounce off a lot of the food I was salting. Nothing special to me about the taste!”* — 3★, Maldon Salt, id srs-743892039014 (Flavor / taste quality)

4. Positioning, target customer & validation (proposals, not evidence)

Target customer (assumption): home cooks who already buy premium finishing salt and gift food items.
Positioning (proposal): globally inspired, botanically infused finishing salts with documented provenance in resealable rigid packaging, addressing the measured complaint themes above. Prices and features are not yet tested.

1. **Smoke test:** landing page with 3 SKUs and a gift set; measure email sign-up rate from ~$200 of targeted ads.
2. **Packaging test:** mail 20 home cooks a pouch vs. a resealable tin; survey clumping/spillage after 4 weeks.
3. **Blind taste panel:** 15–20 participants compare an infused prototype vs. a leading competitor; ask a true NPS question.

Key uncertainties: retrieval caps, one SKU per brand, review volume ≠ sales, keyword coding misses sarcasm/negation, and no evidence yet that customers will pay a premium for infusion or provenance.